

Module 12: Maintaining the Certification

Topic: Keep the Certification

Importance of Certification

- a. External recognition is valuable but should translate into real business benefits.
- b. A management system must be actively utilized and effective.

Key Strategies to Maintain Certification

1. Effective Operation of the Management System

- a. Ensure compliance with policies and procedures.
- b. Generate all planned records.
- c. Follow processes as outlined and maintain standards.
- d. Focus on continual improvement.

2. Adaptation and Updates

- a. Regularly review processes and records.
- b. Modify processes as necessary for improved effectiveness.
- c. Embrace changes as signs of a dynamic management system.

3. Annual Activity Agenda

- a. Maintain a calendar for key activities:
- b. Internal audits
- c. Management reviews
- d. Customer feedback collection
- e. Monitoring and control meetings
- f. Review of corrective actions
- g. Risk assessments

4. Training and Integration of New Personnel

- a. Ensure new employees understand the management system.
- b. Train them on policies, procedures, and strategic objectives.
- c. Avoid loss of discipline and standardization by equipping new hires with knowledge.

5. Motivating Top Management

- a. Ensure the management system aligns with management's objectives.
- b. Use the system as a tool to support their goals.
- c. Regularly communicate the business benefits of maintaining the management system.

By implementing these strategies, organizations can effectively maintain their certification and ensure their management system contributes positively to business outcomes.

Improving the Management System

Monitoring and Performance Management

- a. Operate Under Established Procedures: Follow the procedures and rules set for the management system.
- b. Monitor Real Performance: Regularly assess the actual performance against desired outcomes.

Identifying Gaps and Improvements

- a. Gap Analysis: Identify discrepancies between real and desired performance.
- b. If a gap exists, consider corrections and improvements.
- c. If no gap is found, continue with current procedures.

Continuous Improvement Cycle

- a. Post-Certification Growth: Improvements should be ongoing and become more effective with each monitoring cycle.
- b. Regular Monitoring: Track progress of management system objectives and operational indicators.
- c. Use simple statistical techniques to analyze data.
- d. Look for trends and visualize data through graphics.

When to Adjust the Management System

- a. Trust in System: If performance indicators are stable and meeting objectives, no immediate improvements may be necessary.
- b. Action on Poor Indicators: If indicators trend poorly, consider corrective actions without overhauling the system.
- c. Example: Address specific customer complaints causing a majority of issues.
- d. Example: Recognize one-off production dips due to external factors rather than systemic issues.

Implementing Creative Actions

- a. Corrective Actions: Go beyond temporary fixes (band-aids).
- b. Conduct thorough symptom analysis.
- c. Determine real root causes.
- d. Develop an implementation plan and verify effectiveness.

By regularly monitoring and assessing your management system, you can ensure it remains effective and continues to meet organizational goals.

Top Management Leadership

Role of Top Management

- a. Bigger Picture Perspective: Evaluate if policies and objectives remain relevant and effective.
- b. Double Loop Learning: Engage in a learning process that questions and changes underlying assumptions, improving the control system's intelligence.

Single vs. Double Loop Learning

- a. Single Loop Learning: Focuses on monitoring performance and improving processes to maintain commitments (e.g., delivery times).
- b. Double Loop Learning: Involves recognizing outdated assumptions (e.g., delivery time as a competitive advantage) and adjusting strategies accordingly.

Importance of Communication

- a. Cultural Foundation: Foster a culture of improvement, openness, and participation through effective communication.
- b. Two-Way Communication: Ensure employees understand:
 - c. The organization's values and objectives.
 - d. Their contributions to these objectives.
 - e. Any changes to objectives they can influence.

Demonstrating Leadership and Commitment

- a. Proactive Leadership: Develop key moments for top management to visibly demonstrate commitment to the management system.
- b. Integration into Agenda: Ensure that the management system's importance is a priority in top management discussions and decisions.

By actively engaging in double loop learning and fostering open communication, top management can ensure that the organization remains agile, responsive, and aligned with its strategic goals.

Keeping the Management System Updated

Document Management

- a. Nominate Document Owners: Assign responsibility for each document to ensure regular reviews.
- b. Annual Review: Conduct periodic reviews, usually annually, to recommend updates and changes.

Competency Management

- a. Address New Activities: Ensure the management system adapts to new activities by assessing the necessary competencies.

Supplier and Partner Evaluation

- b. Performance Monitoring: Regularly evaluate suppliers and outsourcing partners against organizational requirements.
- c. Collaborative Problem Solving: Assess if collaboration can help solve common issues or if alternatives are needed.

Stakeholder Satisfaction Monitoring

- a. Actionable Feedback: Gather meaningful feedback from stakeholders about their satisfaction and improvement areas.
- b. Continuous Improvement: Use stakeholder insights to enhance operations and address their concerns.

Risk Management

- a. Review and Update Risks: Regularly review risks and controls, especially after significant changes or at least annually.
- b. Implement New Controls: Based on risk assessments, update and implement necessary controls.

Compliance Monitoring

- a. Stay Informed: Keep track of new or updated standards, legislation, and regulations relevant to the organization.
- b. Implement Changes: Ensure timely study and implementation of changes needed to comply with updated requirements.

By maintaining an updated management system, organizations can remain responsive to changes, enhance performance, and continue to meet stakeholder expectations.

Preparing for the Next Surveillance Audit

Certification Body Guidelines

- a. Contact Certification Body: If uncertain about guidelines, reach out to the Certification Body for clarity.

- b. Avoid Assumptions: Misinterpretations can jeopardize your certification status.

Internal Audits

- a. Policy and Procedure Compliance: Use internal audits to ensure adherence to established policies and procedures.
- b. Effectiveness Review: Regularly assess the usefulness and effectiveness of these policies to foster discipline and drive improvement.

Surveillance Audit Focus

- a. Emphasis on Internal Audit Reports: Surveillance auditors will scrutinize internal audit reports to gauge how well the system is monitored, controlled, and improved.
- b. Monitor Performance: Conduct regular monitoring and management reviews to confirm that the management system is effective and functional.

Management Review Importance

- a. Showcase Leadership: Management reviews are vital for demonstrating top management's commitment and leadership.
- b. Align with Business Challenges: Ensure the management system is aligned with organizational objectives and challenges to prevent it from becoming a burden.

Maintaining an effective management system through continuous monitoring, internal audits, and management reviews is essential for success in upcoming surveillance audits.

What is the Surveillance Audit?

Overview

- a. Purpose: Conducted after a successful certification audit, typically annually or every six months.
- b. Nature: An on-site audit performed by the certification body.

Audit Focus

- a. Non-Conformities: The audit may issue non-conformities that need addressing.
- b. Audit Report: An official report is provided to record the findings of the audit.

Differences from Certification Audit

- a. Sampling Approach: Unlike certification audits that assess all processes in detail, surveillance audits focus on sampling.
- b. Key Activities: Auditors primarily examine:

- c. Management reviews
- d. Internal audits
- e. Corrective actions
- f. Complaint handling
- g. Selective Areas: They may review only specific parts of the organization, such as:
- h. One operating activity instead of all
- i. Selected sites rather than multiple locations

Goal of Surveillance Audits

- a. Three-Year Cycle: The certification body aims to review all processes and business sites at least once during the three-year surveillance cycle.

Surveillance audits play a critical role in maintaining certification by ensuring ongoing compliance and effectiveness of the management system while focusing on key activities and processes.